recanting later. The third round of talks between the military commanders was held on 30 June, followed by a fourth round on 14 July. The PLA was keener on de-escalation and concerned about our continued build-up, whereas we were insisting on disengagement from the friction points and a return to the status quo ante, i.e., as prevailing in April 2020. Both sides prepared their respective proposal based on their viewpoints, but nothing much changed on ground. Contrarily, the PLA continued improving their posture, building shelters and field defences, which was a sure indication of their long-term intent.

During the first round of talks, discussions on disengagement had commenced starting from the friction points of PP-14, PP-15 and PP-17A, as suggested by the PLA. It was while we were still working out the modalities of this, that the clash at Galwan had occurred, leading to a setback in the disengagement process. This issue was revived during the second round of talks and many proposals and counter-proposals were made. While there was a general consensus on both sides to fall back, the sticking point remained as to what would be the reference point for the disengagement, as this could become a benchmark for any future border settlement. When the DGMO and I brainstormed on this issue, we thought why not have two reference points, with each side falling back a specified distance from their respective reference points? This matter was brought forward in the CSG deliberations and thought to be practical. The discussions during the third round on 30 June revolved around this and the PLA also seemed to be on board. Accordingly, a tentative plan was made out wherein the PLA would remain 5 km to the East of their reference point, thus taking them about 3 km East of PP-14. Similarly, the IA would remain 5 km East of our reference point, putting us slightly West of the River Nala Junction (Estuary). The area between the two reference points,

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